

Study Guide & Discussion Companion

for

Digital Mensches: The Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior

A Resource for Counselors, Educators, Parents, and Community Leaders

This guide is designed to help adults review, discuss, and offer
feedback or revisions on the Ten Commandments document.
Use it for staff training, committee review, parent education, or personal reflection.

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How to Use This Guide

This study guide serves multiple purposes. It can be used by a team of camp counselors preparing for the summer, a synagogue education committee reviewing digital ethics programming, a group of parents discussing online safety and AI, or an individual educator deepening their own understanding. The guide is structured in three parts:

Part One: Personal Reflection

Individual exercises to engage with each commandment before group discussion, including an AI self-assessment.

Part Two: Group Discussion

Structured prompts for exploring the commandments together, including *chevrutah* (study-partner) activities and scenario-based role-plays.

Part Three: Feedback & Revision

A structured process for reviewing the Ten Commandments document and offering constructive suggestions for improvement.

Suggested Time Frames

Quick Review (45 minutes): Focus on Parts Two and Three with a single commandment of your choice.

Half-Day Workshop (2–3 hours): Complete all three parts, covering 3–5 commandments in depth.

Full Study Series (5+ sessions): Dedicate one session per 2 commandments, completing the full guide over several weeks.

AI Focus Session (60–90 minutes): Concentrate on the commandments where AI is most prominent (II, V, VII, VIII, X) and the AI-specific scenarios in Part Two.

An Important Note

This document was developed with the assistance of AI tools for research, drafting, and revision, modeling the kind of transparent, human-guided AI use these commandments advocate.

Part One: Personal Reflection

Complete these exercises individually before any group discussion.

Exercise 1: Self-Assessment

Read through all ten commandments. For each one, honestly rate yourself on a scale of 1 to 5 (1 = this is a real struggle for me; 5 = I consistently live this value online). There are no right answers. This is a private reflection.

#	Commandment	Rating (1–5)	Notes
1	Recognize the Divine		
2	Guard Your Tongue		
3	Honor and Protect Dignity		
4	Be a Mensch		
5	Seek Truth		
6	Protect Privacy		
7	Take Responsibility		
8	Observe Digital Shabbat		
9	Pursue Digital Justice		
10	Repair the World		

Exercise 2: Personal Story

Think of a specific moment when you witnessed or experienced either the best or worst of online behavior. Write a brief account (3–5 sentences). Which of the Ten Commandments does your story connect to? How did the experience affect you?

Exercise 3: Your AI Story

Reflect on your own relationship with AI tools. Have you used AI chatbots, writing assistants, or image generators? Did it raise any ethical questions for you: about honesty, about effort, about where the content came from? If you haven't used AI tools, what assumptions or concerns do you bring to the conversation? Be honest. Many adults feel behind on this topic, and that is perfectly normal.

Exercise 4: The Jewish Value That Speaks to You

Of the Jewish values paired with these commandments, which one resonates most deeply with you personally? Why? Has your relationship with this value changed in the digital age?

Part Two: Group Discussion

These activities are designed for groups of 4–20 participants. Adjust as needed for your setting.

Opening Ritual (5 minutes)

Begin by reading aloud: "*Derech erez kadma l'Torah*" : basic human decency precedes even Torah itself (Vayikra Rabbah 9:3). Invite a moment of silence for each person to consider what "decency" means in the spaces where they spend time online, and in their interactions with AI.

Activity 1: Chevrutah Study (20 minutes)

Pair participants into *chevrutah* (study-partner) pairs. Assign each pair one or two commandments. Each pair should:

1. Read the commandment aloud together, including the Jewish value and the “What Teens Are Saying” section.
2. Discuss: Does this commandment feel realistic and practical for you, or the teens you work with? Why or why not?
3. Discuss: Is the Jewish value well-matched to this digital ethics principle? Can you think of a different or additional Jewish text that could strengthen it?
4. Discuss: If AI comes up in this commandment, does it feel natural or forced? Would you adjust it?
5. Discuss: What is one concrete scenario from your experience where this commandment would apply?
6. Prepare a 2-minute summary to share with the larger group.

Activity 2: Large Group Discussion (20–30 minutes)

After *chevrutah* pairs report back, facilitate a large group conversation using these prompts:

- Which commandment do you think would be hardest to follow? Which would be easiest? Why?
- Are there any commandments that feel like they are in tension with each other? (For example, "Seek Truth" vs. "Guard Your Tongue": when might honesty and restraint conflict?)
- The document cites research showing that teens are becoming more critical of social media. Does that match your experience or the experience of the teens you serve?
- AI concerns are woven throughout the commandments rather than treated separately. Does this integration feel right, or would your community benefit from a standalone AI focus?
- Commandment X introduces *bal tashchit* (do not waste/destroy) in connection with AI's environmental impact. Is this a conversation you've had with others? How might they respond?
- Commandment V addresses intellectual property and *geneivat da'at* (theft of the mind). How do you, or the teens you work with, think about AI-generated art and writing? Do they see an ethical issue there?
- Commandment VII connects *yegi'ah* (effort) to academic honesty with AI. How would you draw the line between using AI as a helpful tool and using it to avoid learning?
- Commandment IX addresses digital justice and the gap in access to technology and AI tools. How does the digital divide show up in your community? What responsibility do we have to ensure that digital Jewish spaces are accessible to everyone?
- Is there a commandment missing? What online behavior or Jewish value would you add?
- How would you adapt the language for your specific age group, or the group with whom you work (elementary, middle school, high school, college)?
- The document is grounded in Jewish values but many of these principles are universal. How would you use this in settings with diverse religious backgrounds?

Activity 3: Role-Play Scenarios (15–20 minutes)

Divide into small groups. Each group receives a scenario card and must identify which commandments apply and role-play a constructive response.

Scenario: The Screenshot

A student takes a screenshot of an embarrassing private message from another student and shares it in a group chat. Several others have already seen it by the time a teacher finds out.

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Rumor

A teen in your youth group posts a vague but clearly negative story on social media that everyone knows is about another member. Comments start piling on.

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The AI Essay

A student submits a beautifully written essay for a Jewish studies class. Another student says they saw the first student copying and pasting from ChatGPT. The student says they "just used AI to help organize their thoughts." Where is the line?

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The AI Companion

A 14-year-old in your youth group mentions that they talk to an AI chatbot every night because "it understands me better than my friends do." They seem to be pulling away from real-life social connections.

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Deepfake

Someone uses AI to put a classmate's face on an embarrassing or inappropriate image. It's circulating in a group chat. The creator says it was "just a joke."

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Stolen Art

A student uses an AI image generator to create artwork for a school project. Another student points out that the AI was trained on real artists' work without permission. The first student says, "I didn't steal anything. The AI made it."

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Environmental Question

During a discussion about *tikkun olam*, a camper asks: "If AI uses so much energy and water, is it ethical for us to use it at all?" How do you guide that conversation?

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Misinformation Share

A participant shares a dramatic news story in the group chat that turns out to be AI-generated misinformation. Others have already reposted it.

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Pile-On

Someone in your community posts an unpopular opinion. Within hours, dozens of people are attacking them in the comments, some using AI to generate mocking responses. Some of the attackers are people you know and respect.

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Scenario: The Comparison Trap

A student tells you they feel terrible about themselves after scrolling through a classmate's social media feed, which seems to show a "perfect" life full of AI-enhanced photos.

Which commandments apply? What would you do?

Part Three: Feedback & Revision Process

This section provides a structured process for reviewing the Ten Commandments document and offering constructive feedback. The goal is not to critique for its own sake but to strengthen the document so it can serve your community as effectively as possible.

Step 1: Individual Review (10–15 minutes)

Using the worksheet on the next page, review each commandment and note your feedback in three categories:

- **Strengths:** What works well? What language, values, or framings are particularly effective?
- **Concerns:** Is anything unclear, potentially alienating, missing important nuance, or not age-appropriate?
- **Suggested Revisions:** Specific wording changes, additional Jewish sources, updated research, or structural suggestions.

Pay special attention to the AI-related content woven throughout: Is it well-balanced? Does it feel natural within each commandment, or does it distract from the core ethical message? Are the concerns about environment, intellectual property, shortcuts, and critical thinking addressed in the right places?

Step 2: Small Group Synthesis (15–20 minutes)

In groups of 3–4, share your individual feedback and identify areas of consensus. Each group should prepare a summary of their top 3–5 recommendations:

1. Highest-priority revisions (changes the group feels are essential)
2. Suggested additions (new content, sources, or commandments to consider)
3. AI integration feedback (is the balance right? too much? too little? in the wrong places?)
4. Contextual adaptations (changes specific to your community, age group, or setting)

Step 3: Full Group Report & Consensus (15–20 minutes)

Each small group shares their top recommendations. A facilitator records all suggestions and leads a consensus-building discussion. Key questions:

- Which recommendations have the broadest support?
- Are there any suggestions that conflict with each other? How do we resolve them?
- Is the AI content well-calibrated for the age group(s) you serve?
- What is our timeline for producing a revised version?
- Who will be responsible for incorporating the feedback?

Feedback Worksheet

Reviewer Name: _____ Date: _____

Role/Context: _____

#	Strengths	Concerns	Suggested Revisions
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

Overall Comments

What is the overall strongest aspect of the Ten Commandments document?

What is the single most important change you would recommend?

Is the AI content woven throughout the document well-balanced for your context?

Is there anything missing that you feel is essential to include?

Would you recommend this document for use in your community? (Circle one)

Yes, as-is

Yes, with revisions

Not yet: needs significant work

Facilitation Tips

Set the Tone

Begin by acknowledging that digital ethics is a rapidly evolving area where even experts disagree. This is a learning community, not a test. Model vulnerability by sharing your own digital struggles.

Honor Multiple Perspectives

Participants may range from tech-skeptical to tech-enthusiastic. Create space for all perspectives. The Jewish tradition of *machloket l'shem shamayim* (disagreement for the sake of heaven) is a valuable frame.

Don't Panic About AI

Many adults feel overwhelmed by AI. Normalize this. You don't need to be an expert to lead these conversations. The ethical questions about honesty, effort, dignity, stewardship, and connection are deeply human questions that Jewish tradition has been wrestling with for millennia. Lead with the values, not the technology.

Center Youth Voices

Whenever possible, include teens in the review process. Their insights are essential. Remember that 64% of teens already use AI chatbots, and they likely know more about the day-to-day reality than many adults.

Be Concrete

Abstract principles become meaningful through specific stories and scenarios. Encourage participants to share real (anonymized) examples from their own communities.

Avoid Shame

Many adults feel embarrassed about their own online behavior or AI use. The goal is growth, not perfection. That is a deeply Jewish approach (*teshuvah* is always possible).

Follow Up

Commit to a specific timeline for incorporating feedback and sharing the revised document. A review process without follow-through undermines trust.

"It is not your responsibility to finish the work, but neither are you free to desist from it."

Pirkei Avot 2:16